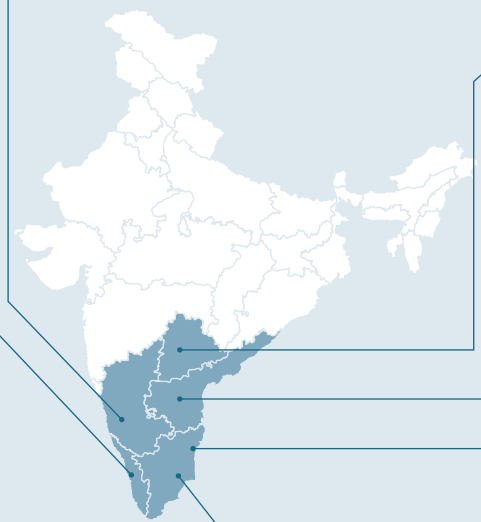
THE COMBAT ZONE

Improving its 2014 tally, the BJP managed to corner 22 per cent of the Lok Sabha seats in the South in 2019, though a bulk of them came from Karnataka

Total seats in South **130**

BJP tally in 2019 **29**

BJP tally in 2014 **21**



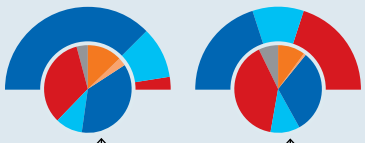
KARNATAKA 28



	2019	2014
BJP	25 (51%)	17 (43%)
JD(S)	1 (10%)	2 (11%)
Cong.	1 (32%)	9 (41%)
Others	1 (7%)	0 (5%)

Note: The JD (S) was a Cong. ally in 2019

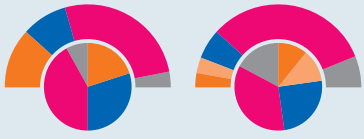
KERALA 20



	2019	2014
BJP	0 (13%)	0 (10%)
Allies	0 (2%)	0 (0.5%)
Cong.	15 (37%)	8 (31%)
Allies	4 (10%)	4 (11%)
LDF	1 (34%)	8 (40%)
Others	0 (4%)	0 (7.5%)

SEATS WON (Vote share)
Total seats
Vote share figures have been rounded off

TELANGANA 17



	2019	2014*
BJP	4 (20%)	1 (11%)
TDP	DNP	1 (12%)
Cong.	3 (30%)	2 (25%)
TRS/BRS	9 (42%)	11 (35%)
Others	1 (8%)	2 (17%)

**Figures extrapolated from Andhra Pradesh results as Telangana had not been carved out when the elections were held; DNP is 'did not participate'*

PUDUCHERRY 1



	2019	2014
AINRC	0 (31%)	1 (35%)
Cong.	1 (56%)	0 (26%)
Others	0 (13%)	0 (39%)

Note: Instead of the AINRC, the BJP is representing the NDA in 2024

believes the era of Dravidian supremacy, which had its genesis in the 1950s and '60s, is coming to an end. Most of its stalwarts are ageing or dead, and its dynastic predilections have resulted in lacklustre leadership. He therefore finds the conditions ripe for a national party like the BJP with a strong "development-oriented local leader" to make major inroads into the state.

Except that the DMK- and Stalin-led SPA will be no walkovers. For one, Stalin's election campaign is immaculately planned and executed. In the temple town of Chidambaram where he held a massive rally, the dais was in the shape of the old Parliament building with pictures not just of erstwhile DMK leaders but also of allies, including Sonia Gandhi and Rahul. His speeches are precisely worded where he berates the BJP for its autocratic ways and plays up the 25 welfare guarantees the I.N.D.I.A. alliance has promised to implement if it comes to power. It is a commanding performance that gives his supporters the confidence to take on the mighty BJP. The party can at best push its own vote share beyond 15 per cent and with allies to 20 per cent to emerge as the principal challenger to the DMK when the 2026 assembly polls come around.

There are two other states where the BJP has struck alliances with parties to beef up its numbers. In Andhra Pradesh, where the party drew a blank in 2019, it moved swiftly to patch up with old regional ally—the Telugu Desam Party (TDP), headed by the ageing warhorse Chandrababu Naidu. It hopes to ride piggyback on the TDP, which won a mere three out of 25 seats

THE BJP HAS FAILED TO NOT ONLY CRACK THE STRONG LINGUISTIC-CULTURAL PRIDE PARTIES IN THE SOUTH FOSTER, BUT ALSO THE NOTION OF A NORTH-SOUTH DIVIDE